

My SQL: Free your mind

Oracle may bring back the key MySQL developers, or work closely with them, to get the development back on track (which had earlier got hit under Sun). There already are two licences for MySQL—this will help Oracle. It will keep the FOSS version at par with the commercial version, or could even adopt Red Hat's model of subscription. This way, big enterprise will replace Microsoft's SQL with MySQL owing to the two biggest benefits—its open nature and support by a trusted corporation like Oracle. If customers want high scalability and are looking for Oracle DB, the transition would be smooth, so there will be market confidence regarding the adoption of MySQL instead of Microsoft solutions.

OpenOffice.org: Good bye, Mr Anderson

This is one market where Microsoft dominates and dictates terms. Recently there were reports that its MS Office SP2 has serious issues regarding interoperability with ODF. This could have been done to scare away people from using ODF and stay with OOXML. Oracle may integrate OOo with its communication suite, pump money into its development and enhance features. It will then push OOo to its corporate customers and dent Microsoft's market share. End users will get a much more polished product with the stable backing of a giant.

Home users: You've been living in a dream world, Neo

Once Oracle sees improved business through these products, it will do something it never did before—target home users. The same products—GNU/Linux and OpenOffice.org—will be available for home users, and Oracle will drive companies like Adobe and the rest to offer binaries for the Linux platform as well. Then graphic designers will have products like CS5 running on top of Linux. Oracle will carpet the world with Linux.

Hardware: Never send a human to do a machine's job

Larry Ellison has already said that he is going to keep Sun's hardware unit. This may initially scare partners like HP and Dell, and push them towards Microsoft. But starting a war against other hardware vendors will make no business sense for Oracle. It will continue to reap benefits from Sun's hardware install base, and continue the development of new hardware to offer its solutions in an optimised manner. At the same time, it will work with vendors like HP to optimise on their hardware as well. Oracle will keep hardware only as an additional unit to continue to earn from the installed market, but will never push it for new customers. It will offer a choice between its own hardware and that from its competitors, as long as they use Linux as well as their database.

Microsoft doesn't have a nut in the hardware segment, let alone a whole box, so the company will not be able to dictate terms and exploit penetration. [I am not talking about a mouse, keyboard and Xbox. I am talking about serious products.]

My way... or the highway

All this means one thing Microsoft may realise that the market can no more be controlled only on the basis of dominance. What Microsoft is facing in the online business will be repeated in the desktop and enterprise segments. The company will be forced to accept the terms of a free market economy. Going forward, the only thing that would ensure the future of Microsoft will be true innovation and fair business practices.

This is something Microsoft is not very good at, but I never said they couldn't improve. 

By: Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.



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